

Italian Romanesque churches

Despite its Roman Italian origin, the Romanesque style south of the Alps followed its own unique path – in part because of the political autonomy of the Italian regions. Romanesque churches in Italy generally followed the plan of traditional basilicas (see here) but, in Lombardy in particular, they developed a more ambitious appearance. Colourful Tuscan marble, used widely in Pisa and Florence, created strikingly variegated exteriors, in contrast to Romanesque churches elsewhere. For instance, San Miniato al Monte (pictured), built in the 12th century in Florence, follows a classical and elegant style, with blind arcades and a patterned marble façade. The Baptistery of St Giovanni, built in Florence in 1059–1128, is octagonal and embellished with white and green marble. The classically influenced buildings in Pisa's Piazza del Duomo, begun in 1153, include the Baptistery, with its transitional Romanesque-Gothic style; the Duomo, or cathedral, sheathed in white banded marble and delicate arcades; and the famously leaning Campanile, or bell tower, also ringed with arcades.

